Chapter 10 · Story

A crash. A full room. A moment of hesitation.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



Who will do something? · c10s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Why could concerned bystanders hesitate?

A Concern disappears when groups become large.

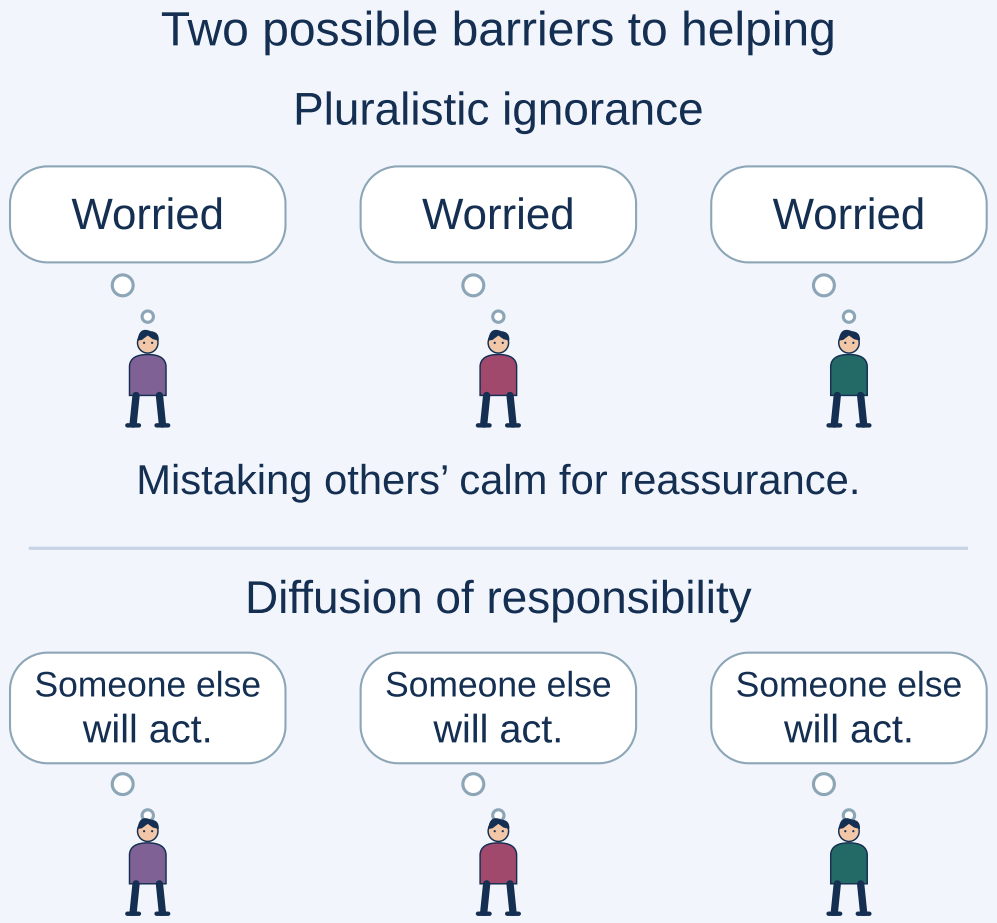
B People may be uncertain and assume someone else will act.

C Hesitation proves nobody cares.

Suggested answer: B. People may be unsure whether help is needed, or think someone else is responsible for acting.

Two reasons concerned people may hesitate.

- **Bystander effect**: others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping.
- **Diffusion of responsibility**: someone else will act.
- **Pluralistic ignorance**: others look calm, so perhaps no help is needed.
- Context can also make other people a source of help.



In some settings, others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping. These are two possible processes; context, skills, and support also matter.

Give concern a workable next step.

- **Notice**: clarify what needs attention.
- **Responsibility**: agree who will take the next step.
- **Action**: use appropriate skills, training, and support.
- **Review**: check the outcome for a low-risk shared task.

Turn concern into a safe path to action

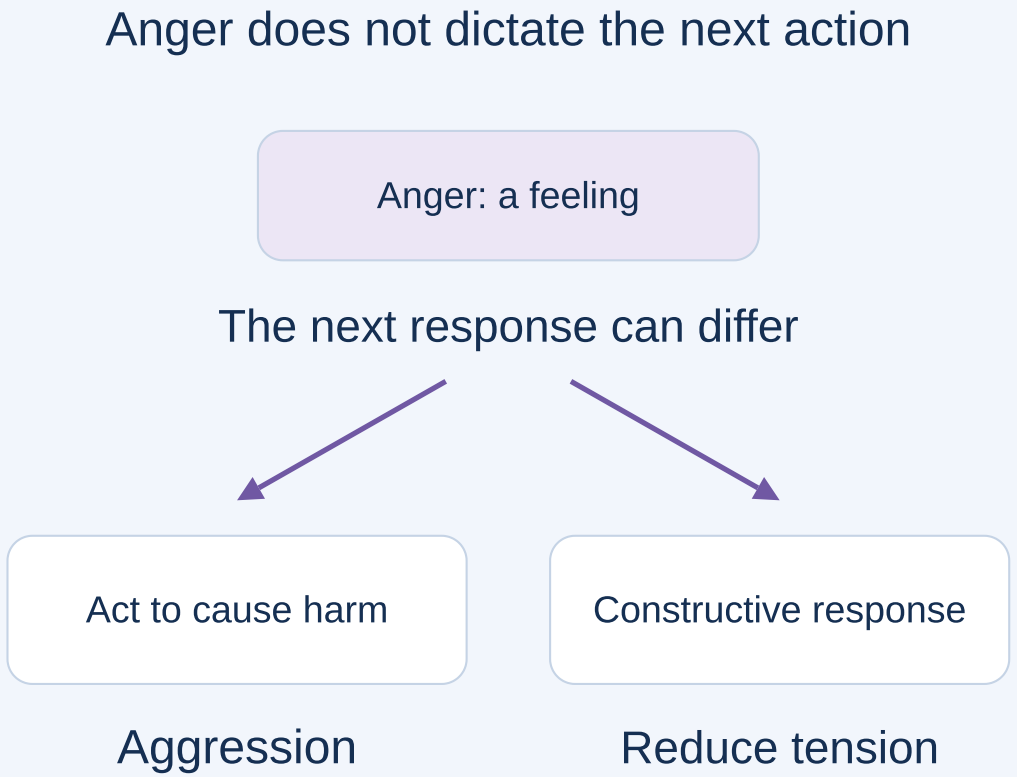
1. **Notice and interpret the need**
   Clarify what is happening
2. **Accept responsibility**
   Agree who will take the next step
3. **Identify an appropriate safe action**
   Use available skills, training, and support
4. **Act and review**
   For a low-risk task, check the outcome

In emergencies, follow local guidance and training.

Clear responsibility, skills, and support can make action feasible.

Anger leaves a choice about action.

- **Aggression**: behavior intended to harm.
- Anger is a feeling; it does not determine the next action.
- **De-escalation**: reduce tension and the risk of harm.
- Context helps explain conduct without removing responsibility.



De-escalation aims to reduce the risk of harm.
Context helps explain behavior; accountability remains.

A feeling does not predetermine a harmful action.

Turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

- **Cooperation**: coordinate contributions toward a shared outcome.
- Name roles and provide resources and support.
- Agree how problems will be raised.
- Review contributions, benefits, burdens, and feedback.

Make a shared task workable

1. **A clear shared outcome**
   What needs to be done?
2. **Named roles and resources**
   Who owns each step and has support?
3. **A route for reporting problems**
   What happens if the plan becomes unsafe?
4. **Feedback and a fair division**
   Review contributions, benefits, and burdens

For example, name who checks the replacement shelf.

A specific arrangement can turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

What can we really conclude?

Laboratory studies may measure aggression through controlled tasks, such as choosing an unpleasant noise for another participant. Such measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence outside the laboratory. Bystander findings also vary with danger, relationships, and available support. “Crowds don’t help” hides those differences and cannot explain every incident. For a real emergency, follow local guidance and your training. A social psychology explanation does not replace first-aid instruction. Evaluate practical changes by whether appropriate, safe help becomes more available. A team saying it cares does not establish that its response plan works.

A research measure and a real-world decision

Controlled measure



An unpleasant-noise task measures one laboratory response. It is an imperfect proxy for serious violence.

Real-world context



Danger, relationships, training, and support can change what safe help is possible. Crowds can also help.

Interpret the measure within its limits.
A psychology model does not replace training.

Interpret controlled tasks and real incidents with appropriate limits.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which preparation makes future help more likely?

A Tell everyone to be more caring.

B Assume the most senior person handles all incidents.

C Agree on response roles, training, and a call-for-help route.

Suggested answer: C. Roles, training, and a call-for-help route address ability and responsibility as well as good intentions.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish diffusion of responsibility from pluralistic ignorance.

> Imagine you are reviewing the café’s response to the fallen shelf. Choose two ideas from earlier chapters and explain how each would improve the review.

1. Diffusion of responsibility concerns who should act. Pluralistic ignorance concerns how people interpret others’ reactions.

2. For an incident review, separate observations from blame, compare possible causes, invite independent accounts, or assign clear roles. These draw on chapters one, two, five, and seven.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Design a helping plan for a low-risk shared task: signal, named role, safe action, and feedback. Explain how context, evidence, influence, and group structure shape your plan.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.